

THE TRUE SELF VERSUS SUPERFICIAL PERSONALITY LEVELS;
SIN AND NEUROSIS; SPLIT CONCEPTS CREATING CONFUSION

Greetings, my dearest friends. God bless everyone of you and your dear ones. Blessed is this hour.

The more you work on this path and comprehend the nature of this work, the more will you understand that the aim is to find your real self, your true being, underneath layers upon layers of yourself which, at first glance, seem to be your personality. But the more you proceed, the more do you realize that it is not your real self, but artificial trends and traits you cultivated for so long that they have become your second nature and therefore appear as you. When we think of the real self, we know that it stands for the divine spark. Unconsciously, your concept of it is that this real self is so lofty and so holy that it is utterly foreign to the you with which you are familiar. This not only frightens you a little, but it also discourages you. This is one of the greatest stumbling blocks in finding your real self. The real self is actually so much nearer to you than you realize. In fact, there are areas in your life where you do act out of your real self, but you do not know it because it is such a natural process. As yet, you cannot distinguish between this kind of action and the action coming forth from the superficial layers.

You assume the real, divine self to appear in the form of a rigid perfection with a standardized pattern. This stands in your way more than your imperfections. Your misconception about divine perfection leads you to rigidity and compulsion on the one hand, and to rebellion against it, on the other. You ignore the vital truth that imperfection can lead to and, at present, can even be perfection. For perfection in the real divine sense is relative and depends rather on one's attitude toward oneself and one's acts than on a perfect act as such. In other words, it is never what you do, but how you do it. The act that is deemed right by the whole world and in accordance with all spiritual laws may be dishonest. You may be divided in it and may have committed it out of fear, compulsion, and thus out of the greed to receive love and approval. Then it is not your real self that acts, regardless of how perfect the outer action may seem. On the other hand, your deed may be condemned by the world. It may be contradictory to the final finished product of perfection. But in your present state, it is not just unavoidable, but even necessary. You show yourself as you are, in accordance with your nature, your inner way of growth. If you are at one with yourself about it, fully assuming responsibility for it, ready to pay the consequences, this imperfect act is more perfect, more according to your truth than the former. This is not easy to understand, and it requires a certain amount of insight and progress. It certainly cannot be approached lightly and irresponsibly. Childish willfulness, always wanting to get something for nothing, should not be confused with it.

Now let us try, difficult as this is in words, to determine the difference between your genuine, true self and the superficial self. Whenever you act out of your real self, you are in complete unity with yourself. There is no doubt, no confusion, no anxiety, no tension. You are not concerned with

the appearance of the act in the eyes of others. Nor are you concerned about the principle or rule. You are concerned, however, with the effect of your action on others and yourself, about the consequences. And you chose this alternative because, even though you recognize its imperfections, it seems less imperfect to you than another alternative. It corresponds to your innermost nature. This does not apply, of course, to destructive actions of a crass nature.

On this path, you also learn to analyze what is really destructive and what is not. Often you overlook this consideration completely because you are so conditioned to accept ready-made rules. The rules stand in front of you, blocking the real issue, blinding you to factors behind the rules. These factors may or may not be the contrary of the stiff rule. As long as you do not have the courage to examine the issues, while forgetting the rule, you cannot come into selfhood. You cannot develop true self-confidence to be gained in no other way. For this procedure requires courage -- courage, because you take the consequences upon yourself. It takes courage because you cut the bond of dependency on rules and regulations and thus on public approval -- courage to make a mistake, if necessary, and wisdom because you know that the mistake itself is not so important, but rather your attitude toward it.

Many of my friends have already found some of these aspects. They have begun to act and react according to this truth. But even they still overlook other areas of their life where this recognition has not yet penetrated. The farther you proceed on this road, the more will you become aware of all this. Just now, this subject needs to be stressed, for the mind tends to forget. For those of you who have not come across this vital insight, it is something to meditate upon.

The superficial self may commit an act which is right by all known standards. Yet you feel confused. There is anxiety in you because of it. On the other hand, the opposite course is clearly destructive, and although you may wish to do it, you prevent yourself from doing so because you do not wish to bring harm to others. Therefore you are divided. This indicates that both alternatives you face come from the view of the superficial self. This may also hold true when two alternatives, which seem neither particularly constructive nor destructive, leave you equally dissatisfied. In either case, you are confused because your real self is covered and all alternatives at your disposal come from the outer layers.

Any way you turn, the alternative is always between your childish self-will and the rigid rule or principle. The principle, incidentally, may even be one of your own making and does not necessarily conform to public opinion. These two alternatives leave you utterly dissatisfied. You turn around in circles and cannot find the way out because you concentrate on the outcome and the act, believing one must be right, the other wrong, while you feel both wrong as far as your peace with it is concerned. Each alternative would be dishonest in its own way -- the one because the greedy child wants to grab, the other because it simply conforms and obeys, rather than acting out of conviction.

Whenever you are in crisis and confusion, you find yourself in just such a predicament. The confusion is the greater when you are not clearly aware of these issues. The first step is to clarify the issue as concisely as possible. Even before you can resolve this conflict because you have not as yet found the way out, you will find relief because now, at least, you clearly see what it is all about.

When I speak of actions, I do not mean only outer deeds. All thoughts, emotions, attitudes, inner decisions, and inner behavior patterns are also actions. Now, actions coming from the outer

self always put you into a trap. As I have just indicated, no alternative in sight offers a real solution. One may be outwardly right while feeling wrong and leaving you confused, unhappy, and doubtful. Or both alternatives may be equally dissatisfying for all concerned. Therefore you feel helpless. You hope for and expect a solution that life might offer because you cannot cope with the issue. This helplessness and weakness is, as we discussed in the past, a sign that here we are dealing with the immature, distorted part of the personality. Where you are mature and whole, you will never be dependent on outer circumstances. You can cope with the situation, and even though a certain course may be difficult, you are fully at peace with yourself.

It takes considerable progress in this work and understanding about certain conflicts and distortions in you before you come face to face with this issue where, in particular, you feel helplessly trapped because you see only two dissatisfying alternatives, and you choose one because it seems the lesser evil. That such a situation creates tension, anxiety, hostility, and discontent is only natural. To a degree, you may occasionally succeed in repressing these emotions, but with the result that they will come out in the most devastating way, when you least desire it, and when you no longer are aware as to why you really feel so unpleasant. Before you choose, you may go through stages of battling with yourself. You try to find a solution by thinking processes, by intellectual deliberations that apply to the outer situation. But in this way, no matter how much wisdom and truth you hear and try to absorb from the outside, it serves no good. Inwardly, something remains locked. You are incapable of coming out of this confusion, this trap.

Only recently, I discussed this topic in a slightly different connection. I also discussed the point of relinquishing. Let us now apply both these topics to the freeing of the real self.

My dear friends, whenever you are helplessly trapped in a situation in which all available alternatives are dissatisfying, you are in such a situation because your real self cannot manifest and cannot guide you. The only way to free your real self sufficiently is to find your particular point of relinquishing, which must be hidden somewhere right in the problem with which you are concerned. Once you find this point of relinquishing, gradually, two different alternatives will evolve. One will be the adherence to a rigid principle, be it a general one or be it your own; the other is your own real self that sees a way that may be imperfect at present, but you are willing to undertake this venture with all it entails.

I said it before, and I say it again now, this point of relinquishing cannot be found arbitrarily, nor by any intellectual process. It can be found only indirectly by this work in self-search and with further help and assistance. Suddenly this point of relinquishing will come into sight, clearly and strongly. It may be something very subtle. It may not concern an outer or material giving up at all, but merely an attitude, an emotional gripping of something. But be aware of the fact that the peace, strength, and self-confidence deriving from selfhood can only be attained through finding the point of relinquishing.

So whenever you are gripped in the crisis of confusion, trapped in helplessness, you are bound to find there is something you hold on to tightly, something you think you must have. There is a strong need involved, be it real or false, substituting for the real. When you find this point of relinquishing, as I stated in the lecture, you will not find that you sacrifice anything by giving it up, but you will see that you give up only an illusion, a forcing current, a false need -- something you cannot have through inner forcing anyway. So you will not sacrifice, but you will have a wise and

realistic attitude about it. You will understand that by not relinquishing, you trap yourself, you make yourself weak, dependent, helpless. Therefore the true self cannot manifest. So far, the price you have paid for holding on where you should have relinquished is a tremendous one. You forfeit the peace, strength, self-confidence making it impossible for you to pursue and fulfill a real need for the doubtful benefit of holding on to an illusion, to the desire to receive something for free. The unconscious resistance to relinquish is the strongest reason for inferiority, self-contempt, guilt, weakness, unfulfilled needs, and many outer frictions and difficulties which are a final result of it.

Much of what I said here, I have said in other connections before. But here I simply linked up a number of topics under discussion lately and showed you how you can utilize these various topics and make a whole out of it, provided your inner work brings you to this corresponding aspect within yourself.

Once you have come to this area within, through thinking, feeling, and working it through, you can make an interesting experiment. Observe your past life from the point of view where you were confused and dependent, and where you were free and at one with yourself. By observing the difference, you may find that whenever in life your real self must have been on the surface, there was something you relinquished. Find it perhaps in the positive, and this may make it much easier for you to find it in the negative. It may also make it easier to give up the resistance to relinquish because by your own experience you will see it is something utterly good and favorable. It is reality, while the illusion only breeds conflict. By finding where, through natural development in this respect, your real self was manifest in the past, you will also see that is not something far away and foreign. It is the familiar you in its very best sense.

Occasionally, the question has arisen as to why the approach of these lectures recently has gone more and more into the psychological, rather than into the spiritual. I have given you various answers, reasons, and explanations. I should now like to direct your attention to the following factors. The area of your personality in which you are conflicted and immature, in what modern psychology terms "neurotic," in essence is nothing else than what religion and spirituality term as "sinful" or "evil." It is all the same. I explained to you why we shied away from the crass term of sin. Your destructive guilt feelings on the one hand, your moralizing tendency and idealized self-image on the other, make the terms "sin" and "evil" an even greater obstacle than you encounter anyway on this path. Your often strong tendencies toward self-punishment and self-destruction made it necessary to foster for the longest time a spirit of self-acceptance and forgiveness and tolerance with yourself.

However, there comes a time in your work when it is necessary that you approach and face the afflicted area in you without kid gloves, so to speak -- when you see it in stark reality without any diluting, without shying away from seeing what is there, in its full impact. Wherever there exist your distortions, images, repressions, immaturities -- in short, your neuroses -- there is also sin and evil. For neurosis always means a character defect. You have found, and are bound to see even clearer, how the distortions not only damage yourself, obstruct your own happiness, but are bound to do the same with others with whom you are involved and who are near you. In so-called neurosis is always selfishness, greed, pride, cowardice, egocentricity, ruthlessness all these in one form or another.

If you view your actions, reactions, and attitudes emanating from the afflicted area -- not your true self -- and consider their effect on others, apart from your own disadvantage, you will truly gain

a new perspective and see that it is possible to accept and forgive yourself while still knowing the intrinsic "sinfulness." You will no longer be forced to stand between the alternatives of either self-acceptance and self-indulgence or repentance and self-hate. On one level of your being, this is your dilemma. This, incidentally, is a typical example of one of those conflicts described before. You see these two alternatives, and neither is constructive. This conflict may not be conscious at all, but it accounts for many a resistance. Inwardly, you are confused and fluctuate between these two alternatives. Again and again, you hear that you should learn to accept, to forgive, and to like yourself in spite of your imperfections. But simultaneously you hear of the necessity of seeing yourself "realistically" so that your desire to change will grow. The desire to change can arise only out of true and genuine repentance. This is a strength and a courage which has, as a first step, to accept the blindness, ignorance, and imperfections that still exist, with the realization that all these, in essence, are character defects. In your confusion, you see in each of the two alternatives -- self-acceptance and forgiveness versus the will to change -- a positive and a negative side, and therefore you cannot reconcile the two. You are afraid of forgiving yourself because you fear your own craving for self-indulgence. You also fear to face fully that which is harmful, also to others, because you fear the whip of your own self-hate.

Once you can truly perceive that this alternative is an illusion and exists only because of your confusion, two apparent opposites will become one whole without any negative involved. The two negatives will fall off. They are split and attached to the split of a positive idea. Self-forgiveness and fully facing one's "sin," both derive from courage, humility, and the will to take on self-responsibility; while self-indulgence and self-hate both derive from cowardice, pride, the will not to change but to make the world change, and lack of self-responsibility. Because of the split of both the positive and the negative trends, confusion is the result in the same manner as the split of the original whole entity, with all its confusion and darkness, brought about by the fall.

So long as you find yourself in similar confusion, your true self cannot show you the clear way. You tug on both sides, none leaving you satisfied. Therefore your own impetus is impaired. You make up for this with compulsion, "I must do the right thing," which you then project onto the world. This you resent. You struggle against it. You defy the world while still wanting to find your way. If the way should by chance appear similar as the world's demands, you are further hindered by your rebellion against the world. You have to prove that you do not bow down when, in reality, you would never do so anyway, whether or not your way is similar in manifestation to the world's prescription of it.

This rebellion has a positive aspect too. It suffers the same split as the concept of self-acceptance and the will to change. If you rebel against rigid principles, against perfectionism, and against conformity, it is compatible with acceptance of the inevitable, with humility and with healthy interdependence. On the other hand, appeasement, obedience, and dependence derive from the same greed as childish rebellion and hostility. It is always the same. When a truth is split, incompatible aspects appear on the horizon as a consequence and create a confusion.

The two examples I gave here will show you how wrong is the general concept that a trend or quality is in itself good or bad. This holds true only in a very crass and superficial area, and to a very limited degree. On the whole, it is not true. Each trend or quality, originally, before the split, was good and constructive. It becomes destructive the moment confusion and misconception arise, the

moment one aspect of the trend is misused by the afflicted part of your soul. This, in combination with the general misconception existing in the world, increase the confusion in this respect.

This also results in a difficulty of communication because one person thinks of the constructive side of the trend in question, while the other has the negative and destructive in mind -- just as, for instance, with rebellion, or repentance or self-acceptance. One person may think of the healthy rebellion indicated earlier, of the strength and maturity in real repentance and change, of the humility and realism of accepting oneself as one is. Another thinks of the destructive kind of rebellion with its false strength, defiance, and cruelty, of the unhealthy guilt and self-accusation in false repentance, of the self-indulgence in self-acceptance. These are examples, but you can find the same in any "good" or "bad" aspect or trait in existence. This confusion leads to misunderstanding among people, but most important of all, to confusion and conflict within yourself. And these in turn make it all the more difficult either not to conform to fixed rules or to rebel against everything that is constructive, as well as to what is actually wrong in this world. This kind of rebellion can do nothing to change it, for to do so, you first have to change yourself.

Every trend or quality in existence experiences this twofoldedness. Even an unquestionable quality like love, the most potent force in the universe, is often misunderstood and rejected because it is taken in its distorted form of false sacrifice, possessive domineering, greedy craving, and dependency.

Let us take another quality -- charity. There are many aspects to it: the charity of the spirit, manifesting in tolerance and understanding; the charity of giving material things; the charity of feeling with and for another person, termed compassion. Let us consider the aspect of compassion. As it happens, in the English language you actually have another term, designating the negative aspect of it -- and that is pity. But you do not have it in all languages. In the English language, this just happens in this respect, but for many other trends or qualities, only one term exists so that confusion is more apt to exist. But even when two terms are available, it is still so easy to be confused as to which is which. How often does it happen that a person feels pity while he is convinced that he has compassion. It is always tempting to pride oneself with a positive attitude, thus covering up a negative one.

Why is pity destructive? Apart from the obvious, which you all know perfectly well and which I do not have to discuss further, it is also destructive because it paralyzes you. In compassion, you are strong and capable of helping, of doing something for the other person. In pity, you can do nothing but weep for the other, while in reality you weep for yourself due to your unwillingness to accept life and death, to take responsibility upon yourself which makes you capable of coping with life's hardships. In pity, you merely project your own weakness onto another, your own cowardice and hidden rebellion. Therefore it is an utterly selfish emotion.

The way to determine whether you feel compassion or pity is to see whether the feeling gives you strength for the other person or persons involved, or whether it weakens you. If the latter holds true, you now know the procedure of looking beyond it and seeing what you can find. Where do you hold a misconception? Where are you trapped into confusion? Where do you repress? Compassion makes you feel and understand, but it is strong enough not to paralyze you, to help, if need be, and, if it be for the good of the other person, even with a momentary bitter medicine.

In the future, you will come across other trends confusing you because of a split in the concept. If you have sufficient awareness of your confusion and conflicts, this will appear on the surface. Before the confusion is cleared up, you will already feel a liberation because you are then fully aware of the problem and see it. At such times, I shall be happy to clarify such confused, split concepts in the manner I have done tonight.

And now, my dear ones, I'm ready for your questions.

QUESTION: I always felt guilty because I didn't have real pity for my mother. I had compassion for her, and because of that, I was able to help her. If I would have had pity, it would have been impossible to help. But in spite of that and in spite of knowing it, I feel guilty.

ANSWER: But the guilt, my dear, you do not have, as you put it, because you did not have real pity. Your guilt has nothing to do with pity or compassion. It has to do with entirely different aspects where there was no healthy approach in yourself, and towards your mother. As I told you already in the past, your guilt has nothing to do directly with your relationship to her. It is an indirect outcome of other aspects within yourself.

QUESTION: With regard to what you said before, I'm just about to lose my closest friend. And I would like to be able to get to the point of having compassion and losing any kind of pity.

ANSWER: The answer is implicit in this lecture. Find where you identify with this friend. What the friend experiences, you fear for yourself. This fear is repressed and therefore can't be dealt and come to terms with. Thus it manifests in pity.

QUESTION: It is more the loss I feel than identification.

ANSWER: It is also an identification. The grief of losing a dear one is a pain that has to be borne. In itself, it is a healthy pain that cannot weaken the soul, provided it is gone through. But the additional element in your pain is fear. And where the fear is, identification occurs. The quality of these two pains is different if you probe your emotions. The quality of pain of loss does not contain the fear, bitterness, self-pity, struggle, and hardness contained in the pain of identification -- pity.

QUESTION: In the last lecture, with reference to defense mechanism, you said that the basic defense is a general inner climate you can feel. Could you please explain what you mean by "inner climate?"

ANSWER: If you observe your emotions, which you increasingly learn to do on this path, you will detect the kind of feeling that can best be described as an inner stiffening. It may not always be on the surface. There has to be a reason or provocation for it -- for instance, when you do this work with another person and certain areas are touched, or when you encounter or apprehend criticism or disapproval. You will detect a hardening, a fearfulness, an apprehension, a desire to reject whatever it is that comes to you. You feel attacked and threatened. The feeling in you, coming as a reaction to the elements just mentioned, is your defense mechanism. Once you feel it, it is a great step forward, for then you will come to see how you react due to its existence and

how such reaction is against your interest. You have to observe this inner climate, this stiffening and hardening; otherwise you cannot get further in this important respect of the work.

QUESTION: You didn't exactly define pity and compassion, as I remember. I would like to know a little more what the difference is between the two. It seems to me that in the work you prescribe, the more we acknowledge and understand ourselves, the more are we able to act according to a rule, that is, to live together. Apart from that, the more we do in this work, we become less human and more machines. I believe the very core of humanity is pity, and indeed, self-pity, because if a person does not have self-pity, he is not selfish. If a person is not selfish, he is not human, he is a god. This is not a mental or intellectual consideration, but something I feel.

ANSWER: In the first place, I do not think it is necessary to repeat now the difference between compassion and pity. I have defined it sufficiently in the lecture. If you read it, I do not believe you will have any difficulty in understanding. However, if a question remains open, I shall be glad to answer it after you have studied the lecture.

As to the rest of your question, there are a number of confusions and misunderstandings contained in it. For instance, you say that at the core of every human being is pity, indeed self-pity. No, this is not true. Either pity or self-pity is the result or the symptom, not even of the core, but of another symptom. There are many attitudes and aspects in the human being that are a part of a chain reaction. The core is the real self -- and this most certainly does not act according to any rule, neither a general, outer one, nor even to a rigid self-made one. Its nature is flexibility and individuality.

Although it is human to be selfish, it is also human to be unselfish. Although it is human to have self-pity, it is also human not to have it. It is not that the one is human and the other divine. Both are human. With selfishness, it is the same as with any other trait. There is a healthy, as well as an unhealthy, destructive kind. Your confusion here arises out of the ignorance in this respect in that you believe you are expected to give up any kind of selfishness. Therefore you rebel against it and cannot accept giving up the kind of selfishness that is destructive of yourself and others.

Moreover, I should like to say that if you believe that the outcome of this work is conforming to a rule and to become like a machine, you have not even understood the most basic rudiments of this work. It is time for you, with your good intelligence, to understand it, at least in your brain. For the truth is the extreme opposite of what you stated here. It is significant, and it applies to every human being, regardless of his intelligence, that wherever he has a resistance to understand, he not only does not hear the points that he is unwilling to understand, but actually he often hears the very opposite. The essence of these lectures, teachings, and the method of this work is to free you of the ready-made rules and become true individuals. In tonight's lecture, this point was again stressed from a new angle.

You are under the misconception that goodness is dull, has no variation, is always the same insipid lack of individuality, humor, pleasure, wit. You ascribe all that to "badness." How wrong you are! Goodness is as diversified as badness. Only it has more humor, individuality, pleasure because in health and maturity -- which amounts to the same as "goodness" -- you are better able to express yourself, you experience more keenly, you have a deeper, wider scope for living. You

confuse goodness with "goody-goodyness," which, if really analyzed, is the extreme opposite of the former. In essence, goody-goodyness is another facet of the badness that seems so desirable to you.

In this very lecture, I mentioned, among other things, that it is sometimes better to make a mistake if it comes out of yourself than to obey rules and principles when you are not at one within yourself about them. Isn't it significant that you hear the very opposite? Doesn't that show something very vital in your attitude toward yourself? Do you understand, my friend?

QUESTION: Yes, I understand your words. But what you see then becomes a rule if you say that I or we or mankind must aim to become oneself. Then this is a rule.

ANSWER: No. You can choose to remain infants if you so desire. You do not have to grow up. But if you wish to grow and live a constructive and full life and want to realize most of your potentials, then you must become yourself. But the choice has to be made by you.

QUESTION: I understand. Then there is a further question. Why then should such advanced people, shall we say people who have been on this Path for some time, say that by doing this work, by realizing oneself, by throwing off fetters, they then become able to withstand what no human wants to withstand, such as another person's ill manners, etc.? Now, I do not think that is honest or the aim, to be able to withstand things which are...this seems to me like being a machine?

ANSWER: There is another confusion here, my friend. The answer here is very simple. Growth, maturity, unfoldment makes you able to withstand, if you have to, that which you are incapable of changing. It makes you able to give up so that you do not have to stand things you do not have to endure -- something the immature person cannot do, and therefore unbearable things become a problem for him. You rebel against things you cannot change because they are outside your control. If you believe that your rebellion alleviates the difficulty, you are very much mistaken. Quite the contrary is true. The mature person can take what has to be taken without being crushed. He will even derive benefit from it out of his mature attitude. This certainly does not make a machine out of him. It would be more appropriate to call the perpetually rebelling person a machine, an ineffectual one, at that. He constantly puffs aimless steam into the atmosphere, which depletes his strength so that he becomes incapable of changing the issues he could change, which are not outside of his control. He is unaware that he could do so, and unwilling because he cherishes the pseudoindividuality of the perpetual rebel. What makes you believe you are more of an individual and less of a machine when you constantly scream and fight where there is no reason to do so? What makes you believe that the person is a machine who faces an issue squarely, and upon discovery that here is something he cannot change, he goes with the stream, thus saving his strength for the many issues where he can change and thus make his life more meaningful?

Let me part from you this time with very special blessings, in this time of year, honoring the greatest being who ever lived, the being who had taught and lived and died by all the truth conveyed again and again in so many various ways ever since your earth began to exist -- Jesus Christ. Be blessed in Him, be in peace, and may your further path make you realize that His teachings, as well as any other teachings of truth, do not seek to make you conform, appease, bow down, and accept something against your will and conviction by making you into puppets and goody-goodies. Quite the contrary! If you truly understand and follow His teachings and certain aspects of His life, you will find this so. That He, as well as any other exponent of truth, has not only taught but also lived

it is very opposite to that which the rebellious person fears most -- the goody-goody conformer. Watch, observe yourself and others. Go deeper in this work. See the few people whom you may know who have already accomplished a part of this goal, and you will see this is true. The more spiritually and emotionally a person is developed, the more is he alive, the more is he a distinct individual, the less is he a machine, apart from his warmth, courage, and humor. The true self, regardless whose, is very opposite of that which you fear and rebel against.

And so, my friends, be blessed in the Lord.

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